

Reality Drift Project Index

A Guide to the Core Papers, Definitions, Visual Frameworks, and Applications on OffBrandGuy

A. Jacobs – Reality Drift Framework

The Reality Drift project spans concept papers, definitions, visual models, interpretive essays, diagnostic guides, and applied examples. This index brings together the most important public materials available on OffBrandGuy.

It is not a complete archive of everything published through the project. It is a guided map of the pages that best explain the framework, its core concepts, its underlying mechanisms, and its applications across modern systems, artificial intelligence, culture, cognition, and everyday life.

[Start Here](#)

A guided introduction to the Reality Drift project, its major ideas, and the best entry points for new readers.

[What Is Reality Drift?](#)

A direct introduction to the central idea: systems can remain functional while gradually losing alignment with the realities they were created to represent or serve.

[Reality Drift — Canonical Overview and FAQ, 2023–2026](#)

The primary overview of the framework, including its scope, central claims, boundaries, related ideas, and frequently asked questions.

[Reality Drift — Definitions and Core Concepts](#)

The main glossary for the Reality Drift framework, bringing together its central vocabulary and conceptual relationships.

[Reality Drift Canonical Concept Papers](#)

An index of the fourteen canonical papers defining the project's core concepts, mechanisms, and system-level conditions.

Canonical Definitions

The canonical definitions provide concise, stable reference points for the framework's major concepts.

[Reality Drift](#)

The condition in which systems remain operational while gradually losing alignment with real-world feedback, lived experience, or underlying purpose.

The Drift Principle

The principle that systems tend to drift when compression and optimization advance faster than the constraints capable of preserving alignment.

Recursive Compression

The process through which systems simplify reality into representations, reuse those representations, and progressively build new models and decisions on top of them.

Semantic Fidelity

The degree to which meaning, intent, context, and reference survive as information moves through systems and transformations.

Constraint Collapse

The condition in which feedback remains present but loses its ability to enforce correction, invalidate error, or stop misaligned processes.

Temporal Drift

The misalignment between system time and real-world time, including delayed feedback, accelerated updates, and decisions made on incompatible timelines.

Cognitive Drift

The condition in which thought remains active and coherent while becoming increasingly dependent on mediated inputs and recursive representations rather than direct grounding.

Co-Cognition

The shared cognitive process through which human thought and external systems, especially AI systems, jointly generate and refine representations through repeated exchange.

The Optimization Trap

The condition in which measurable efficiency becomes easier to improve than the real-world purpose a system was meant to serve.

Filter Fatigue

The cognitive exhaustion created by continuous sorting, comparison, curation, and relevance filtering in information-dense environments.

Synthetic Realness

The perceptual inversion in which optimized or artificial representations begin to feel more authentic than the realities they represent.

The Drifted Self

The condition in which identity remains functional and socially legible while gradually losing continuity, grounding, and internal coherence.

The Age of Drift

The broader environment that emerges when Reality Drift becomes a persistent condition across institutions, technologies, culture, cognition, and identity.

Visual Frameworks and Diagrams

The visual framework collections trace the development of Reality Drift through diagrams, conceptual maps, system models, loops, stacks, and comparative structures.

Reality Drift Framework 2024

An early visual collection introducing the initial structure, language, and conceptual direction of the Reality Drift framework.

Reality Drift Framework 2025

A developed visual account of how systems drift from reality through optimization, abstraction, weakened feedback, and representational distance.

Reality Drift Framework 2026

The current visual diagram collection, including models of recursive compression, constraint collapse, semantic fidelity, survivable wrongness, and system-level drift.

Semantic Fidelity Visual Frameworks

Visual models examining meaning preservation, semantic degradation, representation chains, recursive transformation, and failures of grounding.

Framework Structure and System Mechanics

These materials describe the internal architecture of the framework and the mechanisms through which misalignment develops.

Reality Drift Ontology: Concepts, Operators, and Relations

A structured map of the framework's major concepts, transformations, properties, relationships, and system dynamics.

Mechanisms of Misalignment in Modern Systems

An examination of the recurring mechanisms that allow systems to preserve coherence and performance while losing contact with real-world conditions.

Reality Drift Cross-Domain Interpretations

A collection of papers connecting Reality Drift to adjacent theories, disciplines, and modern system problems.

Conceptual Briefs

Short papers focused on central cultural and structural concepts, including the Optimization Trap, Synthetic Realness, Filter Fatigue, and related forms of modern drift.

Semantic Fidelity and AI Systems

The Semantic Fidelity paper collections apply the broader framework to language models, retrieval systems, representational pipelines, evaluation, and AI-mediated reasoning.

[Semantic Fidelity Project Glossary](#)

Definitions for the central vocabulary of the Semantic Fidelity Project, including semantic drift, constraint collapse, recursive compression, grounding, interpretation failure, and meaning degradation.

[Semantic Fidelity Core Paper Series](#)

The central papers defining Semantic Fidelity and examining how meaning changes as language moves through compression, transformation, generation, and evaluation.

[Representational Systems in AI](#)

A paper series examining AI systems as representational structures that compress, transform, retrieve, and regenerate information.

[Failure Modes in LLM Systems](#)

A collection focused on the recurring failure modes of large language models, including interpretation failure, evaluation misalignment, embedding distortion, multi-agent drift, and silent semantic degradation.

[AI Systems and Reality Drift](#)

A paper series connecting artificial intelligence to the wider Reality Drift framework, including model coherence, weakened grounding, recursive reuse, benchmark optimization, and representational misalignment.

Cognitive Drift and Human–AI Thought

[Cognitive Drift Papers Glossary](#)

A glossary of concepts related to cognitive drift, distributed cognition, recursive thought, mediated reasoning, AI-assisted thinking, and the changing structure of human cognition.

Essay and Interpretation Maps

[Reality Drift Essay Map](#)

A guide to the major essays, interpretive pieces, and long-form arguments developed across the Reality Drift project.

Recognition and Diagnosis

These collections help identify how drift appears before a system visibly fails.

Reality Drift Recognition Guides

Practical guides for recognizing Reality Drift, Filter Fatigue, the Optimization Trap, Synthetic Realness, and related conditions in ordinary systems and experiences.

Signs of Modern Drift

A visual and interpretive collection documenting recurring signs that systems, environments, and everyday experiences are becoming less grounded.

Modern Questions

Short explanations applying Reality Drift to common questions about why modern life feels increasingly artificial, difficult, procedural, overloaded, or detached from purpose.

The Texture of Modern Life

These collections document how structural drift appears in ordinary environments, routines, interfaces, and repeated behaviors.

Everyday Reality Drift Scenes

Illustrated examples of modern friction, including app-dependent parking, medical check-in systems, account migrations, QR menus, two-factor authentication, digital returns, and fragmented workplace tools.

Behavioral Rituals of Modern Life

A visual collection examining repeated behaviors that have become normalized within digital and mediated environments, including checking notifications, scanning QR codes, waiting for typing indicators, and reaching for a phone upon waking.

Institutions and Corporate Drift

A visual and conceptual series examining how organizations can preserve procedure, reporting, compliance, and performance signals while losing contact with mission, outcomes, or lived conditions.

A Suggested Reading Path

New readers can begin with *What Is Reality Drift?* and then move to the *Canonical Overview and FAQ* for a fuller explanation of the framework. The *Definitions and Core Concepts* glossary provides a useful reference for the project's central language.

The *Canonical Concept Papers* offer the clearest introduction to the individual ideas. The visual framework collections can then help show how those concepts connect and operate across different systems.

Readers focused on artificial intelligence may want to continue with the *Semantic Fidelity Core Paper Series*, *Representational Systems in AI*, and *Failure Modes in LLM Systems*.

For more grounded and everyday applications, the *Recognition Guides*, *Modern Questions*, *Everyday Reality Drift Scenes*, and *Behavioral Rituals of Modern Life* show how the framework appears in ordinary experience.

The *Reality Drift Ontology*, *Mechanisms of Misalignment in Modern Systems*, and *Cross-Domain Interpretations* provide a more detailed account of the framework's structure, mechanisms, and theoretical connections.

About OffBrandGuy

OffBrandGuy is the primary public web archive for the Reality Drift project by A. Jacobs. The site brings together conceptual writing, canonical definitions, visual frameworks, AI and semantic-fidelity research, cultural interpretation, and applied examples of how modern systems can remain functional while gradually losing alignment with reality. This index highlights the most important materials. Additional essays, papers, diagrams, visual collections, and archival documents are available throughout the site.